Read Words in Context

READ!

The Vanishing Dog Towns

A prairie dog stood on its hind legs searching for danger. It spied a slight movement in the grass and gave a call of alarm—a high-pitched noise that sounds like a dog's bark. Badgers—their number one enemy—could be coming! The **gravity** or **seriousness** of the danger was not known yet. The prairie dog raised up higher to see beyond the **gnarled** scrub bushes that were **knotty**, or lumpy, and twisted with age. Then, with relief, it gave the "all-clear" bark.

Prairie dogs live in colonies or towns. At the entrance to their tunnels are large, cone-shaped mounds of dirt. These mounds serve as lookouts and also help prevent the flooding of their tunnels. The tunnels go down **corridors**, or **hallways,** that are about 15 feet underground. If tunnels get **drenched** or **soaked** in a heavy rainstorm, it could mean trouble. That's why near the entrance is an escape chamber, along with a sleeping chamber, and food storage chamber. When a **commotion** or noises are heard, a call is given. This results in a **bustle** of activity as the dogs quickly head for safety.

In 1804 prairie dogs were spotted by the Lewis and Clark expedition. By 1900 there were about five billion prairie dogs living in North America. Today prairie dogs are in danger because many people don't like them and often kill them.

These animals are **pesky** and **troublesome** to farmers because they eat grass meant for livestock. Even so, some farmers allow small colonies on their lands. They give their **consent** or **approval**. It's the larger colonies that concern them. Scientists, however, view prairie dogs as an important part of the prairie habitat. They want farmers to understand this. They speak carefully and try not to **fumble** their words. They do not want to **mishandle** the situation and make the farmers angry.

The arguments between scientists and farmers are ongoing. People try to be **civil**, or **polite** and respectful. There would be no **honor** or **glory** for anyone if these animals became extinct.

Vocabulary Words

approval	**gravity**
bustle	**hallway**
civil	**honor**
commotion	**knotty**
consent	**mishandle**
corridor	**pesky**
drenched	**polite**
fumble	**seriousness**
glory	**soaked**
gnarled	**troublesome**

Word Learning Tip!

A **synonym** is a word that means the same or nearly the same as another word. You can learn the meaning of synonyms by finding the word or words in a sentence that are used to define them.

Vocabulary Building Strategy

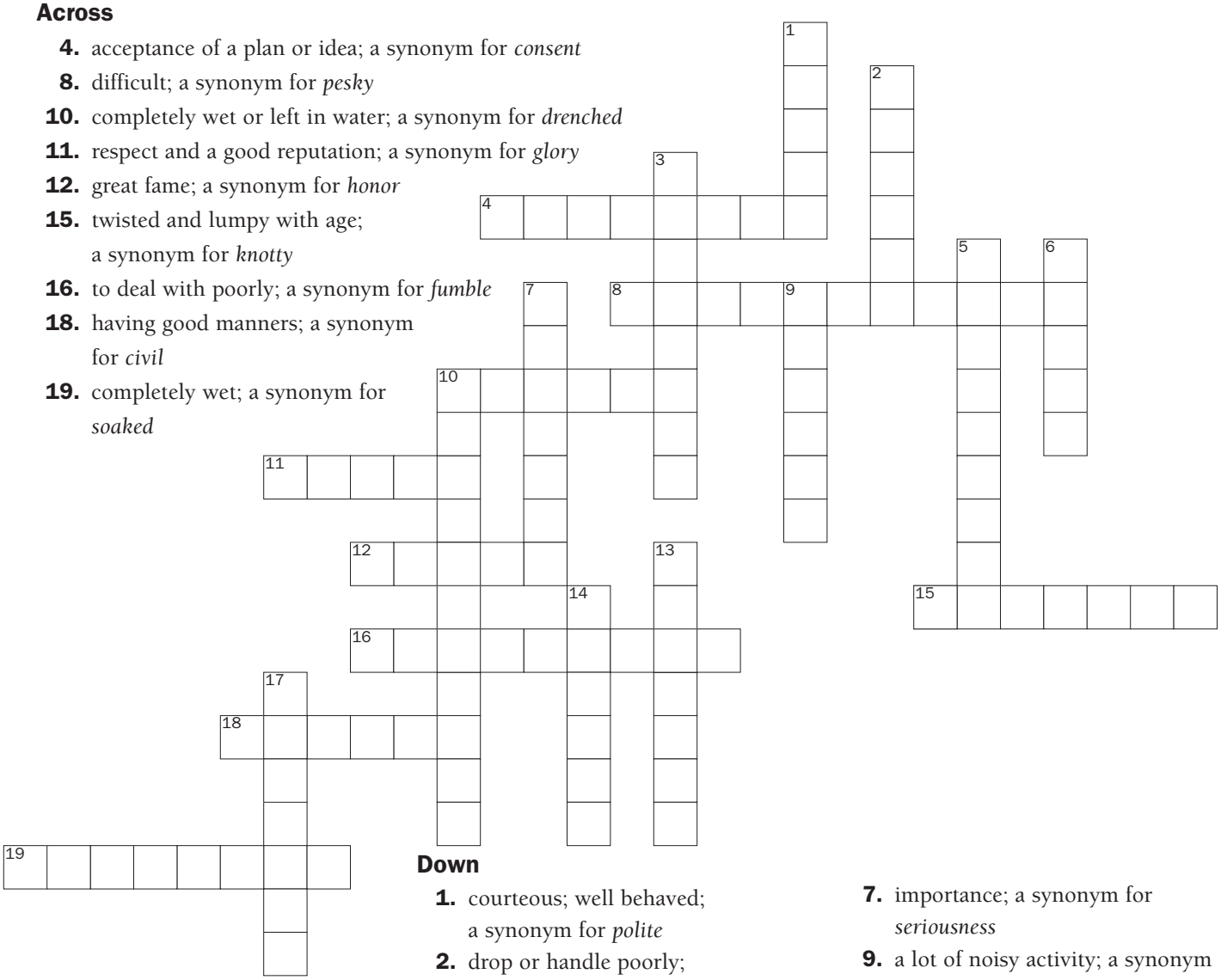
Use Context Clues You can often find the meaning of a synonym by using the context clues—the words and phrases around it. Sometimes a synonym's meaning is the word that comes right after the word *or* or *and* that follows it. For example, "The winning team's locker room was filled with commotion *and* bustle."

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Connect Words and Meanings

approval	consent	glory	honor	polite
bustle	corridor	gnarled	knotty	seriousness
civil	drenched	gravity	mishandle	soaked
commotion	fumble	hallway	pesky	troublesome

Directions Use the clues below to fill in the crossword puzzle. You may use the glossary.



Across

4. acceptance of a plan or idea; a synonym for *consent*
8. difficult; a synonym for *pesky*
10. completely wet or left in water; a synonym for *drenched*
11. respect and a good reputation; a synonym for *glory*
12. great fame; a synonym for *honor*
15. twisted and lumpy with age; a synonym for *knotty*
16. to deal with poorly; a synonym for *fumble*
18. having good manners; a synonym for *civil*
19. completely wet; a synonym for *soaked*

Down

1. courteous; well behaved; a synonym for *polite*
2. drop or handle poorly; a synonym for *mishandle*
3. a passageway; a synonym for *hallway*
5. rush; lots of activity; a synonym for *bustle*
6. annoying; a synonym for *troublesome*
7. importance; a synonym for *seriousness*
9. a lot of noisy activity; a synonym for *commotion*
10. importance; a synonym for *gravity*
13. a long passageway; a synonym for *corridor*
14. having many hard spots or lumps; a synonym for *gnarled*
17. agreement; a synonym for *approval*

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Connect More Words and Meanings

approval	consent	glory	honor	polite
bustle	corridor	gnarled	knotty	seriousness
civil	drenched	gravity	mishandle	soaked
commotion	fumble	hallway	pesky	troublesome

Directions Read each definition below that describes a pair of synonyms. Then choose the synonyms that match the definition. Write them in the blanks in the sentence.

1. **acceptance or permission** — The townspeople gave their _____ of, or _____ to, the plan.
2. **annoying and bothersome** — The flies buzzing around the tent were _____ and _____.
3. **respectful; not rude** — Although they each had strong opinions, the friends kept the discussion of the problem _____ and _____.
4. **wet through and through** — The rain came down so heavily the children were _____ and their shoes were _____.
5. **importance; significance** — The farmers recognized the _____ or _____ of the problem.
6. **twisted; bumpy** — The limbs of the ancient tree in the backyard were _____ and _____.
7. **lots of movement; hubbub or disturbance** — Around the holidays, there is a lot of _____ and _____ in the stores.
8. **praise and respect** — The soldiers coming home had won _____ and _____ for their brave deeds.
9. **passageway** — The office is at the end of this _____ or _____.
10. **blunder or drop; do something badly** — When the judge spoke to the two lawyers who were arguing, she was careful not to _____ or _____ the situation.

Write a Journal Entry Imagine that you are part of an expedition traveling across America in the early 1800s. You have just seen your first prairie dog colony. Write an entry in your personal word journal. Think about how you would describe the prairie dogs. What is it about them that you find interesting and exciting? Use three sets of synonyms in your entry.

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Use Words in Context

approval	consent	glory	honor	polite
bustle	corridor	gnarled	knotty	seriousness
civil	drenched	gravity	mishandle	soaked
commotion	fumble	hallway	pesky	troublesome

Directions Answer each of these questions with a sentence using two synonyms from your vocabulary words. Use the boldface words to determine which pair of synonyms to use. Write your answer on the line.

1. What have you seen in nature that is **twisted** and **bumpy**?

_____

2. In what ways might an animal be **annoying** and **bother** you?

_____

3. What activities would you have to ask your parents for **permission** to do?

_____

4. What situations require you **not to make jokes and act silly**?

_____

5. What places are filled with **excitement** and **noise**?

_____

6. Which parts of a school are linked by a **passage that people walk through**?

_____

7. Whom do you admire for his or her **good reputation** and **fame**?

_____

8. How do people show that they are **well-mannered** and **act with respect**?

_____

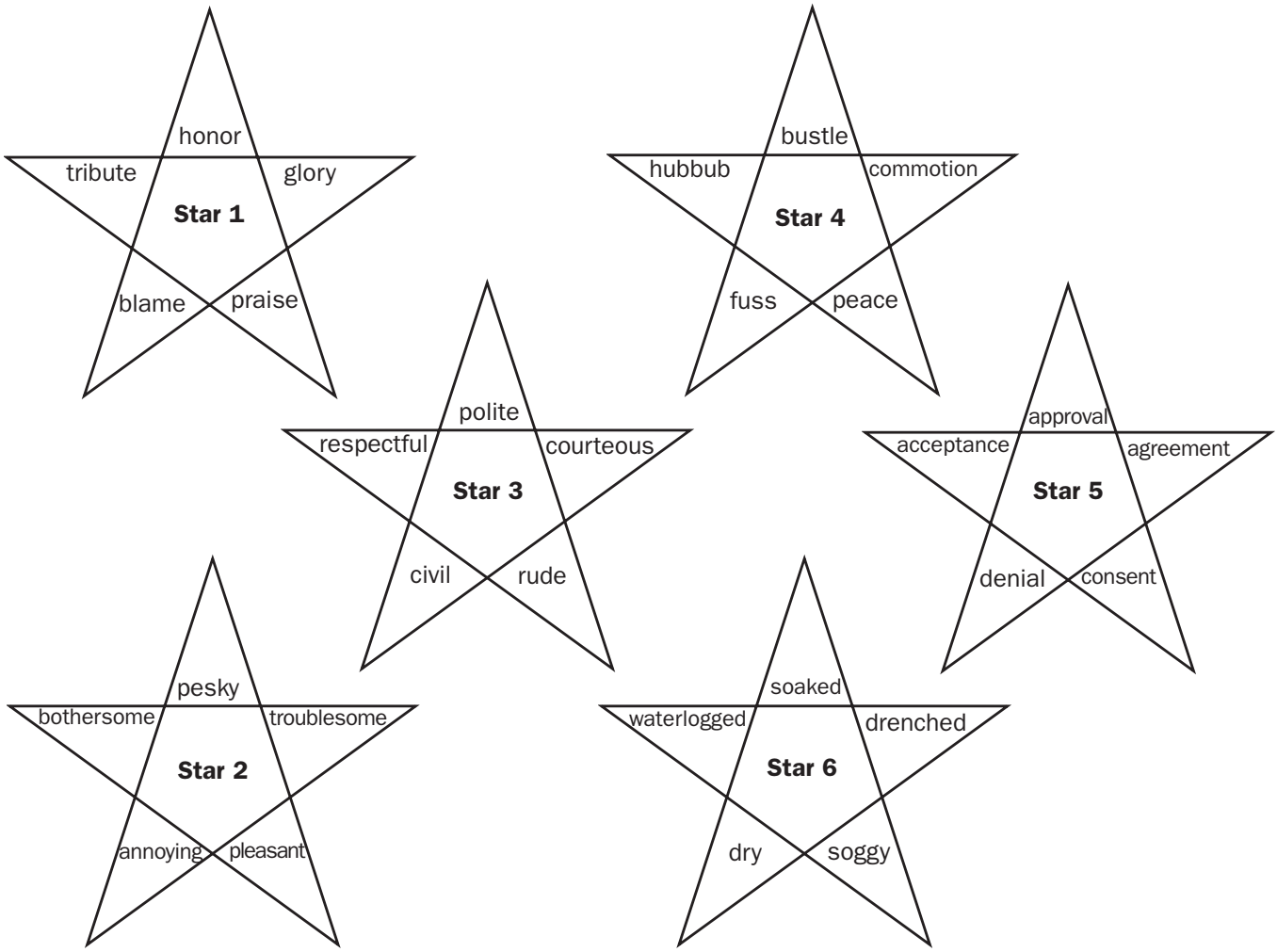
Debate Your Position Work with a partner. Consider the question of whether prairie dogs should be protected. Select either the farmers' side or the scientists' side. Write sentences to support your position, using five sets of synonyms. Be prepared to debate the question.

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Put Words Into Action

approval	**consent**	**glory**	**hallway**	**polite**
bustle	**corridor**	**gnarled**	**honor**	**seriousness**
civil	**drenched**	**gravity**	**mishandle**	**soaked**
commotion	**fumble**	**knotty**	**pesky**	**troublesome**

Directions Look at each group of synonyms below. Cross out the word that doesn't belong.



Interview a Wildlife Scientist Work with a partner to create five or six interview questions to ask a wildlife scientist about prairie dogs or other animals in the wild. Write them in your personal word journal. Take turns interviewing your partner and being interviewed by your partner. Try to include at least four vocabulary words, along with several new synonyms in your questions and your answers.

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Review and Extend

approval	consent	glory	hallway	polite
bustle	corridor	gnarled	honor	seriousness
civil	drenched	gravity	mishandle	soaked
commotion	fumble	knotty	pesky	troublesome

Learn More!

There are shades of difference between two synonyms that makes one of them better to use in a certain situation. For example, both *drenched* and *soaked* mean "to be wet through and through." People can be either *drenched* or *soaked* after a downpour. But *soaked* also means "left something in water." You would say that vegetables left in water were *soaked*, not that they were *drenched*.

Both *polite* and *civil* deal with good manners. *Polite* suggests showing care for others, such as saying "thank you." *Civil* suggests that someone shows good manners, but doesn't really want to, such as when two people who don't really like each other try to be *civil*.

Directions Read each situation. Choose the synonym that best fits the context. Use each word only once. Write this synonym in the blank. You may use a dictionary to help you.

fumbled—mishandled

1. The team lost the point when he _____ the ball.
2. Because the mayor is good with people, she will not _____ this difficult problem.

bustle—commotion

3. When the fire alarm rang, we lined up quickly and didn't make a _____
4. There was a lot of _____ in the house as they got ready for the party.

civil—polite

5. Sonia Jackson and Leslie Gravino have very different opinions, but they were _____ to each other during the debate.
6. My little brother has good manners and is very _____.

Find New Synonyms On a separate piece of paper, draw an ice-cream cone with two scoops on it. Write a synonym pair in the scoops. Work with a partner to find additional synonyms for these words. Add a scoop for each synonym you find.

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Check Your Mastery

Directions Complete each sentence below.

1. If you were **drenched**, your mother might tell you to _____

   _____.

2. You might achieve a lot of **glory** if you _____

   _____.

3. You need your parents' **consent** in order to _____

   _____.

4. There is a lot of **bustle** in the house when _____

   _____.

5. At the end of the dark **corridor** was _____

   _____.

Directions Complete the word analogies below. Write your answers on the lines.

6. **Single** is to **alone** as **civil** is to _____.
   A. polite **B.** approval **C.** honor

7. **See** is to **glimpse** as **mishandle** is to _____.
   A. knotty **B.** fumble **C.** seriousness

8. **Shine** is to **glow** as **troublesome** is to _____.
   A. gnarled **B.** pesky **C.** gravity

9. **Power** is to **strength** as **knotty** is to _____.
   A. gnarled **B.** honor **C.** commotion

10. **Funny** is to **amusing** as **gravity** is to _____.
    A. seriousness **B.** soaked **C.** hallway

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